



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. John Chrysostom Academy
School Website: <https://chrysostomacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St John Chrysostom Academy (Bethlehem, PA 18017) presents a robust classical Orthodox education model. The public materials consistently emphasize a knowledge-centered curriculum anchored in Orthodox Christian formation, with explicit attention to Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as real and knowable realities. The school publicly foregrounds classical elements (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, memory work, liturgical life) and a pedagogy that blends memorization and chant in lower grades with Socratic seminars and rhetorical training in upper grades. Family partnership and a liturgical, communal life are repeatedly highlighted, aligning with the classical rubric's expectations for religious/metaphysical foundations, formation of character, and a communal school culture. Overall, the school aligns with a CLASSICAL orientation across all six categories. Evidence from multiple sources on the site demonstrates explicit commitments to classical education, Orthodox formation, great books and memory-based pedagogy, and active parental involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school identifies itself as an Orthodox private school providing a classical, Christian education and emphasizes Orthodox formation as a core aim.
- Explicit references to liturgy, sacred tradition, and daily prayer as integral to education are present (Divine Liturgy; liturgical year; Orthodox Christian formation).
- The public materials repeatedly frame truth, goodness, and beauty as real and as guiding aims, including discussions of transcendentals and the Good/True/Beautiful as anchors of learning.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; worship; liturgical year; sacred music; Orthodox; divine liturgy; wonder; wisdom; imago Dei (as implied); great books/theology integration. Approximately 10–12 distinct positive indicators are present across materials.
- Negative keywords: not evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral language found in these pages).
- Why this rating
- The school foregrounds Orthodox theology and liturgy as core educational influences, plus explicit attention to transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and sacred tradition, matching the Positive keywords for this category. The absence of any explicit negative signals strengthens the CLASSICAL classification here.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The aim is described as forming virtue and wisdom, not simply information or job-readiness. Statements about formation, the pursuit of truth, and the cultivation of virtue are central (e.g., “knowledge-centered curriculum... ends in and of themselves,” and “promote inquiry to discover what is true and beautiful”).
- The curriculum emphasizes formation via Great Books, memory, and the Great Conversation, with a telos beyond mere information processing.
- There is explicit mention of the aim to prepare for life after graduation in terms of purpose and abilities, with a strong emphasis on inquiry, virtue, and wisdom rather than only career outcomes.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; telos; great conversation; truth, goodness, beauty; liberal education; classical mission. Approximately 6–10 distinct indicators are present.
- Negative keywords present: some language about college/technical pathways appears (e.g., “college or technical undergraduate environment or take the path of work or entrepreneurship”), which maps to “workforce preparation” language in some classical-education lexicons as a potential caution signal. The overall framing, however, remains formation-focused. 1–2 negative-type indicators identified.
- Why this rating
- The program centers formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, with a strong Great Books component and a clearly articulated telos. While there is some mention of post-graduation pathways, the dominant rhetoric remains formation-focused, aligning with CLASSICAL rather than a purely job/career-centric approach.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The curriculum explicitly centers on the liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) and a Great Books-based approach. Materials reference Grammar School through Upper School with classical literacy, writing/ rhetoric curricula, and a focus on memorization, narration, and imitation.
- The school studies history throughout the curriculum (e.g., “story of America and Pennsylvania,” world history sequences, and Story of the World), not merely “social studies.”
- There is direct emphasis on Great Books and the Great Conversation, with reading lists including Homer, Beowulf, Dante, Shakespeare, and canonical works, plus memorization and discussion (narration, discussion, coaching).
- The curriculum integrates languages (Latin and Greek in Middle/Upper School), science (nature study), math (Right Start Math, algebra), and fine arts, including iconography and sacred art, within a cohesive classical framework.
- History and geography are integrated across grades, with a coherent narrative linking local, national, and world history.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium: arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, primary sources, history/Western civilization, Latin/Greek, liturgy in arts, interdisciplinary/harmony of subjects, wonder/integration. Approximately 10–14 distinct indicators appear.
- Negative keywords present: no explicit language that replaces history with “social studies” or that centers on project-based, STEM-first models; some lexicons warn against project-based emphasis, but site materials consistently emphasize canonical, text-rich study. Overall, minimal to no negative signals observed in public content.
- Why this rating
- The school’s published curricula align tightly with classical education tenets: liberal arts focus, Great Books, memorization/recitation, historical breadth, classical languages, and an integrated, wonder-filled approach. This constitutes a strong CLASSICAL alignment.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mixed but distinctly classical pedagogy is described: memorization, narration, imitation; singing/chanting in lower grades; rest and contemplation as part of learning (Scholé); Socratic discussion and seminars in upper grades; students receive training in rhetoric and opportunities to give speeches.
- Lower grades emphasize singing/chanting and memory work; upper grades emphasize Socratic seminars and rhetoric, including oratory and debate. The site explicitly notes that upper school uses rhetoric and oral expression.
- The pedagogy is framed as a balance of contemplative/restful learning and rigorous discussion, with a path from memory-driven early grades to reasoning-based upper grades.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminar; dialectic; great conversation; narration; recitation; chanting; Scholé; rhetoric; memory work; formal coaching; liturgical and moral formation. Approximately 12–14 distinct indicators appear.
- Negative keywords present: very few explicit negative signals; the site does not emphasize purely experiential or constructivist, project-based approaches to the exclusion of traditional methods. If anything, it spaces memory/chanting with Socratic work, which is still classical.
- Why this rating
- The school's pedagogy maps very cleanly onto the classical rubric: memory-based early education, liturgical/scholastic aspects, and upper-level Socratic and rhetorical training. This robustly supports CLASSICAL.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Leadership materials emphasize a board and faculty culture rooted in traditional and virtuous education, with the living curriculum concept and teacher as mentor. The site presents a structured leadership model and a staff roster, and speaks of faculty as core to the school.
- The curriculum itself is described as the “living curriculum” and the school highlights the teachers as models of virtue, skill, and knowledge. The language around teachers and mentorship aligns with classical expectations.
- Public materials emphasize a shared vision with a strong emphasis on classical formation, with indications of teacher training and ongoing classical formation.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers; mentors; portrait of teacher; teacher as exemplar; collegial culture; instruction rooted in classical formation. Approximately 6–10 indicators observed.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public content; no signals of a weak faculty culture or non-classical staffing approaches.
- Why this rating
- The site consistently frames faculty as central to the formation process, with clear emphasis on virtuous, knowledgeable teachers who serve as living exemplars—hallmarks of CLASSICAL schooling.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes partnership with families, parental co-education, and parent formation (e.g., parent information meetings, blog reflections on classical Orthodox education, and open campus ethos). Open houses and parent-facing content are highlighted.
- The school promotes parent involvement beyond mere enrollment, including book studies and family education about classical education, indicating an engaged and forming community.
- The campus emphasizes accessibility for parents (open visits) and the alignment of home and school life with liturgical and educational rhythms.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental formation; home-school

connection; open campus; family catechesis; parent education; classical parent training. Approximately 8–12 indicators appear.

- Negative keywords present: none evident in public content; no customer-only or minimal parent involvement signals.
- Why this rating
- The materials emphasize active parental involvement and partnership, which is central to classical education models that view families as co-educators. This supports CLASSICAL.
- Score rationale: CLASSICAL

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall Classification: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: Across all six categories, St John Chrysostom Academy demonstrates explicit, sustained alignment with classical education principles: a theologically rooted Orthodox formation; a formation-focused purpose; a text-rich, Great Books–driven curriculum; a pedagogy that blends memory, chant, and Socratic inquiry; a faculty culture anchored in mentorship and the living curriculum; and an engaged, parent-partnered community. This constellation of features exceeds the thresholds for a CLASSICAL designation in every category. See evidence across the site for Orthodox formation, Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Scholé/memory-based pedagogy, and family-education partnerships.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. If one sought to further strengthen CLASSICAL signals, the school could consider:
- Making explicit in a public-facing policy statement the central aim of formation (virtue and wisdom) as the primary telos, with job/career pathways framed as secondary outcomes rather than primary goals.
- Providing a more explicit, public cross-wac of Great Books reading lists and primary-source emphases by grade level to further anchor the Great Conversation in every division.
- Adding more explicit statements about the integration of the Quadrivium across upper grades (e.g., astronomy and music integrated with mathematical reasoning in senior years) to reinforce the Seven Liberal Arts framework.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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